

Freelance Pricing & Quote Kit

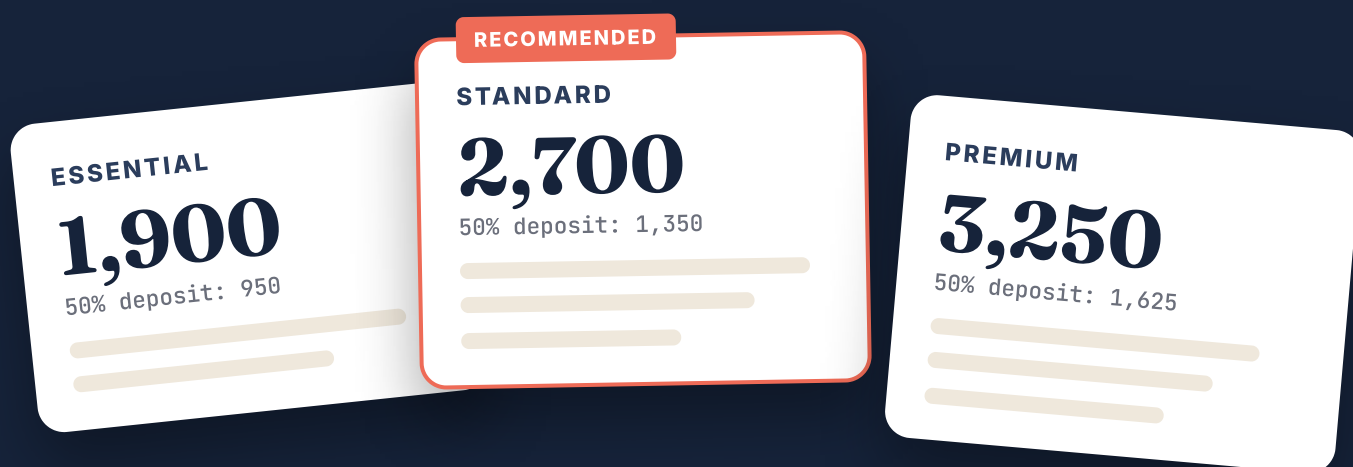
Know your rate. Send a three-package quote clients say yes to. Keep your price when they push back.

XLSX workbook, 6 tabs

Guide: Letter + A4

Client quote template

Copy-paste scripts



START HERE

How to use this kit

This kit takes you from your own numbers to a finished three-package quote you can send today, plus the words to use when the client replies.

Your first 30 minutes

1. **Open `freelance-pricing-kit.xlsx`** (Excel or Google Sheets) and go to the **Floor Rate** tab. Replace Maya's numbers with yours. No spreadsheet app? Use **`pricing-calculator.html`** in any browser.
2. **Read Chapters 1 and 2** while you fill in the **3-Tier Quote** tab for a real project.
3. **Copy the three prices into `quote-template.html`**, click any yellow field to edit it, print or save as PDF, and send it.
4. **Keep Chapters 3 to 6 open** for pushback, extra requests, rate raises and retainers.

What's in the kit

File	What it is
<code>freelance-pricing-kit.xlsx</code>	Workbook: Floor Rate, Market Check, 3-Tier Quote, Change Order, Rate Increase
<code>freelance-pricing-kit-letter.pdf</code> / <code>-a4.pdf</code>	This guide, in US Letter and A4
<code>quote-template.html</code> / <code>.md</code>	Client-facing 2-page quote, editable in your browser; <code>.md</code> to paste into Google Docs or Notion
<code>scripts-and-templates.txt</code>	Every email and script in this guide as plain text, numbered \$1 to \$10
<code>pricing-calculator.html</code>	Offline calculator: floor rate, packages, per-word & retainer pricing, 12-month rate-raise cash flow

MEET MAYA

Every example uses one fictional freelancer: Maya Ortiz, a brand designer two years in. Her numbers are the default values in the workbook and the calculator, so you can check every step.

ANY CURRENCY

All amounts in this kit are currency-neutral. "1,900" means 1,900 of your currency: dollars, pounds, euros or anything else. Type your own amounts the same way.

Disclaimer: this kit is a planning tool, not tax, legal or financial advice. Tax rates are examples; check yours with an accountant. Have a lawyer review contract terms for large projects.

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Every email and script is also in scripts-and-templates.txt, numbered \$1 to \$10 in the same order as this guide.

Find Your Floor Rate



The lowest hourly rate at which freelancing still pays you what you need. Four steps, one worked example.

Your floor rate is the lowest hourly rate at which freelancing still pays you what you need. It isn't your quote. It's the line you never go below. It's easy to skip this step and price from what feels polite, then find out at tax time that you underpaid yourself all year.

The **Floor Rate** tab in `freelance-pricing-kit.xlsx` (and `pricing-calculator.html`) runs this math for you. This chapter shows every step so you can check it.

The formula

Step	What you calculate	Formula
1	Revenue needed per year	$(\text{take-home} \div (1 - \text{tax rate}) + \text{business costs}) \times (1 + \text{buffer})$
2	Billable hours per year	$\text{working weeks} \times \text{hours per week} \times \text{billable share}$
3	Floor hourly rate	$\text{revenue needed} \div \text{billable hours, rounded UP to the nearest 5}$
4	Floor day rate	$\text{floor hourly} \times \text{hours per day}$

WHY EACH PIECE IS THERE

- **Tax:** your take-home goal is after tax, so revenue has to cover the tax as well.
- **Business costs:** software, hardware, insurance, accountant, courses. Clients pay for these through your rate.
- **Buffer:** slow months and late payers happen. The buffer pays for them.
- **Billable share:** sales, admin, invoicing and learning are work, but nobody pays for them by the hour.

Planning tool, not tax or financial advice.

CHAPTER 1 · WORKED EXAMPLE

Maya, brand designer, 2 years in

Input	Maya's value	Why
Take-home income goal (after tax)	60,000	What she wants to live on
Business costs per year	6,000	Software, hardware, insurance, accountant, courses
Effective tax rate on profit	25%	Her rough rate; check yours with an accountant
Savings buffer	10%	Covers slow months and late payers
Working weeks per year	44	52 minus holidays, public holidays and sick time
Hours worked per week	40	All working hours
Billable share	60%	The rest goes on sales, admin, invoicing, learning
Hours in a day rate	8	

WORKED EXAMPLE · MAYA · STEP 1

Revenue needed

$$(60,000 \div 0.75 + 6,000) \times 1.10 \\ = 86,000 \times 1.10$$

94,600 per year

WORKED EXAMPLE · MAYA · STEP 2

Billable hours

$$44 \times 40 \times 0.60$$

1,056 hours per year

WORKED EXAMPLE · MAYA · STEP 3

Floor hourly rate

$$94,600 \div 1,056 = 89.58 \\ \text{rounded up to the nearest 5}$$

90 per hour

WORKED EXAMPLE · MAYA · STEP 4

Floor day rate

$$90 \times 8 \\ \text{monthly target: } 94,600 \div 12 \approx 7,883$$

720 per day

In the workbook: Floor Rate tab, column B. Revenue needed (B16), billable hours (B17), floor hourly (B19), floor day rate (B20), monthly target (B21).

CHAPTER 1 · USING YOUR FLOOR

THE 2,080 MISTAKE

If Maya had divided the same revenue need of 94,600 (tax, costs and buffer included) by 2,080 hours (52 weeks × 40 hours), she would have charged about 45 per hour. That's half her real floor of 90. Her billable hours are 1,056, not 2,080.

$94,600 \div 2,080 \approx 45.5$ vs $94,600 \div 1,056 = 89.58$, so floor 90

Floor rate vs. the rate you quote

The floor is a minimum. Once you know it:

1. **Look at your market.** Check what peers with similar experience charge, using public rate pages, community surveys in your niche, or agencies you subcontract for. Enter up to five of them in the **Market Check** tab with a note on the source. If your market pays more than your floor, quote the market rate.
2. **Never quote below the floor** to win a project. Cut scope instead (Chapter 2: three packages). The Market Check tab shows **BELOW FLOOR** if the rate you plan to quote is too low.
3. **Re-run the numbers every 6 months**, or whenever your costs, tax situation or billable share change.

Common mistakes

Mistake	What to do instead
Using 100% billable time	Nobody bills every working hour. Use an honest share: count last month's billed hours if you have them.
Forgetting tax and costs	Your take-home goal is after tax. Revenue has to cover the tax and the costs too.
Rounding down "to be competitive"	Always round up. The difference is small per hour and large per year.
Treating the floor as a target	It's the line you defend, not where you aim.

NEXT

Your floor (Maya: 90) is now the default quote rate on the **3-Tier Quote** tab. Chapter 2 turns it into three package prices. Worksheet "Your numbers" at the back lets you do this chapter by hand.



Quote Three Packages

Give the client a choice between yeses, and protect your rate by changing scope instead of price.

A single price gives the client a yes-or-no choice. Three packages give them a choice between yeses. They compare your options with each other instead of with a cheaper freelancer, and you can protect your rate by cutting scope instead of price.

How the tiers work

Tag every task in the project with a tier:

Tier	Package	Contains
1	Essential	The core outcome the client asked for, nothing extra
2	Standard	Essential + the things that make it go smoothly (variants, docs, handover)
3	Premium	Standard + speed, support or extra reach

Each package includes every task at its tier and below. The price is:

THE PACKAGE PRICE FORMULA

$\text{hours} \times \text{quote rate} \times (1 + \text{contingency})$

then rounded **up** to the nearest 50 (the rounding step in the workbook).

Contingency (10–20%) covers the email, calls and small surprises that every project has. **Deposit:** ask for one (commonly 30–50%) before you start.

Quote rate: your floor rate from Chapter 1, or a higher market rate. Never lower.

CHAPTER 2 • WORKED EXAMPLE

Maya quotes a brand refresh

Client: Sam Lee, Northfield Coffee. Quote rate: **90/hour** (her floor; she could quote higher).
Contingency: **15%**. Deposit: **50%**.

Task	Hours	Tier
Discovery call & brief	2	1
Core deliverable (logo refresh + palette)	12	1
Two revision rounds	4	1
Extra deliverable (social media kit)	6	2
Handover documentation (mini brand guide)	2	2
Priority support (30 days)	5	3

Package	Hours	Calculation	Price	Deposit
Essential	18	$18 \times 90 \times 1.15 = 1,863$	1,900	950
Standard	26	$26 \times 90 \times 1.15 = 2,691$	2,700	1,350
Premium	31	$31 \times 90 \times 1.15 = 3,208.50$	3,250	1,625

ESSENTIAL

1,900

50% deposit: 950

Discovery, logo refresh + palette, two revision rounds

RECOMMENDED

STANDARD

2,700

50% deposit: 1,350

Essential + social media kit + mini brand guide

PREMIUM

3,250

50% deposit: 1,625

Standard + 30 days of priority support

In the workbook: 3-Tier Quote tab, rows 31–33 (Essential, Standard, Premium): price in column D, deposit in column E, balance in column F.

The quote email (filled in)

Send this with the quote document attached (quote-template.html, saved as PDF). Replace Maya's details with yours.

COPY-PASTE · scripts-and-templates.txt §1

Subject: Brand refresh: three options

Hi Sam,

Thanks for the call on Tuesday. Here are three ways we can do the brand refresh:

Essential: 1,900. Discovery, refreshed logo and color palette, two rounds of revisions.

Standard: 2,700. Everything in Essential plus a social media kit and a mini brand guide your team can use.

Premium: 3,250. Everything in Standard plus 30 days of priority support after launch.

I recommend Standard: it gives your team the files and the rules to use the new look from day one. A 50% deposit starts the work; the balance is due on delivery. This quote is valid until November 30.

Not included: copywriting, printing, and website changes. I'm happy to quote these separately.

The full quote is attached. To go ahead, reply with the package you'd like and I'll send the deposit invoice.

Best,
Maya

WHY THIS EMAIL WORKS

- Three prices, each with what it includes, in one line each.
- One clear recommendation, with a reason that is about the client.
- Deposit, validity date and "not included" are stated before anyone asks.
- It ends with one easy next step.

Rules that protect your rate

1. **If they push back on price, remove scope, never just the number.** Offer Essential instead of a discount. Chapter 4 has the exact replies.
2. **Put the package you want them to pick in the middle** and say why you recommend it. Only recommend what you would choose in their place.
3. **Always write a validity date.** It gives a gentle deadline and lets you update prices later.
4. **Always list what's not included.** Chapter 3 shows you how.
5. **Ask for the deposit before you start.** No deposit, no start date.

Send it as a document

quote-template.html is a client-facing 2-page quote, pre-filled with this example. Open it in any browser, click a yellow field and type. Then print it or save it as PDF (US Letter or A4). It contains:

Page 1	Page 2
Your name, logo and contact details	Payment terms: deposit, balance, late payment
Client, quote number, date, valid until	Change requests and your change-order rate
Project goal	Acceptance: chosen package, name, signature, date
Three packages with prices, deposits and a Recommended tag	Next step
Not included, timeline, what I need from you	

Prefer Google Docs, Word or Notion? Paste **quote-template.md** and keep the same order.

YOUR TURN

Use worksheet "Your quote" at the back of this guide, or the 3-Tier Quote tab (15 task rows). Copy the three prices and deposits into the quote template.

Three packages for other kinds of work

The method is the same in every field: list the tasks, tag the core result tier 1, the things that make it smoother tier 2, and speed, support or reach tier 3. Three illustrations, priced like Maya's (rate 90, 15% contingency, rounded up to 50). The hours are examples, not benchmarks: use your own estimates.

WEB DEVELOPER · SHOPIFY STORE SETUP

Package	Tasks (hours)	Hours	Price at 90
Essential	Discovery & sitemap (3), theme setup + 5 page templates (16), import up to 50 products (4), launch checks (2)	25	2,600
Standard	+ custom collection filters (6), speed & SEO basics (4)	35	3,650
Premium	+ email capture with 2 automations (5), 30 days of support (4)	44	4,600

COPYWRITER · WEBSITE COPY

Package	Tasks (hours)	Hours	Price at 90
Essential	Brief & interview (2), Home + About copy (8), one revision round (2)	12	1,250
Standard	+ 3 service pages (6), second revision round (2)	20	2,100
Premium	+ SEO titles and descriptions for all pages (2), 5 launch emails (6)	28	2,900

MARKETING CONSULTANT · MARKETING AUDIT

Package	Tasks (hours)	Hours	Price at 90
Essential	Kickoff workshop (3), channel audit (10), findings report (5)	18	1,900
Standard	+ 90-day action plan (6), team walkthrough call (2)	26	2,700
Premium	+ 3 monthly check-in calls (4), KPI dashboard setup (5)	35	3,650

Check: $25 \times 90 \times 1.15 = 2,587.50$, rounded up to 2,600. Type the same tasks into the 3-Tier Quote tab (column C = tier) to get these prices, deposits and balances. Ongoing work billed per word or per month: see Chapter 6.

Scope & Change Orders



Five documents that keep a project at the size you priced it.
Replace everything in [brackets].

A good quote can still lose money if the scope is vague. This chapter gives you five documents that keep a project at the size you priced it. Each one is also in scripts-and-templates.txt, ready to paste.

#	Document	When you use it	.txt
1	Scope of work section	Inside your quote or proposal, before the client says yes	\$2
2	Kickoff recap email	On day 1, after the deposit is paid	\$3
3	Change order	When the client asks for something that isn't included	\$4
4	Change log	All project long; share it at each milestone	\$5
5	Reply scripts	The moment a new request arrives	\$6

THE CHANGE-ORDER PRICE FORMULA

$\text{hours} \times (1 + \text{overhead}) \times \text{rate} \times \text{rush multiplier}$, rounded up

Overhead is typically 10–20%. Rush multiplier: 1.0 normal, 1.25 rush, 1.5 urgent. The **Change Order** tab does this for you.

TIP

Aim for 3–5 "Not included" bullets. Choose the things clients in your field most often assume are included.

Templates only, not legal advice. For large contracts, have a lawyer review your terms.

Scope of work section

Paste this into your proposal or quote.

COPY-PASTE · scripts-and-templates.txt §2

Project: [Project name]

Goal: [One sentence on what the finished work should achieve for the client.]

Included

- [Deliverable 1, with a number, e.g. "Design of 5 pages: Home, About, Services, Blog index, Contact"]
- [Deliverable 2, e.g. "Build in WordPress on the client's existing hosting"]
- [Deliverable 3, e.g. "Entry of client-supplied text and images"]
- Revisions: [2] rounds of consolidated feedback per deliverable
- Meetings: [1] kickoff call + [2] check-in calls of up to [30] minutes
- Support: [14] days of bug fixes after launch

Not included (available as add-ons on request)

- [Copywriting or editing of text]
- [Stock photos or paid fonts/plugins, billed at cost if needed]
- [Additional pages beyond the 5 listed]
- [Ongoing maintenance, hosting or updates after the support period]
- [SEO, ads or analytics setup]

Client responsibilities

- Provide [text, images, logins] by [date]
- Send consolidated feedback (one email per round) within [3] working days
- Delays in client materials or feedback move the delivery date by the same amount

Additional work

Anything not listed under "Included" is quoted separately before work starts, at [rate]/hour or as a fixed price agreed in writing through a change order. Rush work (delivery earlier than the agreed timeline) carries a [25]% fee.

Kickoff recap email

COPY-PASTE • scripts-and-templates.txt §3

Subject: [Project]: kickoff recap and next steps

Hi [Name],

Great to get started. A quick recap so we're on the same page:

- What I'm delivering: [short list]
- Revisions: [2] rounds per deliverable, with feedback collected into one email per round
- Timeline: [milestone 1, date], then [milestone 2, date], then launch [date]
- What I need from you: [materials] by [date]
- Not included this time: [the 2-3 most likely assumptions]

If something comes up that's outside this list, I'll quote it before I start, so there are never surprises on the invoice.

Looking forward to it,
[Your name]

Change order (Maya's example)

COPY-PASTE • scripts-and-templates.txt §4

Change order #	1
Project	Brand refresh for Northfield Coffee
Date	November 18
Original agreement	Quote 2026-014, Standard package, accepted November 6
Requested change	Design a loyalty card in the new brand style
Not included in this change	Printing the cards
Estimate	4 hours, including communication
Price impact	+425 , new project total 3,125
Timeline impact	Delivery moves from December 4 to December 8
Payment	Added to the final invoice

All other terms of the original agreement stay the same.

Approved by: _____ **Date:** _____ (a reply email saying "approved" also counts)

How to price a change

Estimated hours $\times$ (1 + overhead, typically 10–20%) $\times$ your rate $\times$ rush multiplier (1.0 normal, 1.25 rush, 1.5 urgent), rounded up.

WORKED EXAMPLE • MAYA • CHANGE ORDER TAB

Loyalty card, 4 hours, normal timing

$4 \times 1.15 \times 90 \times 1.0 = 414$, rounded up to the nearest 25

+425 new project total $2,700 + 425 = 3,125$

Rush version of the same change: $4 \times 1.15 \times 90 \times 1.25 = 517.50$, rounded up to **525**.

Change log

Keep one per project and share it at each milestone.

COPY-PASTE • scripts-and-templates.txt §5

#	Date	Request (who asked)	In scope?	Hours	Price	Status
1	Nov 18	Loyalty card design (Sam)	No	4	425	Approved CO #1
2	Nov 20	Swap one palette shade (Sam)	Small	0.25	0	Done, absorbed (noted)
3	Nov 24	Menu board layout (Jo)	No	5	525	Quoted

Why keep one: small favors you absorb become visible. When they add up, you can bundle them into one change order and have the evidence ready.

Change log row 3: $5 \times 1.15 \times 90 = 517.50$, rounded up to 525.

Reply scripts for new requests

COPY-PASTE · scripts-and-templates.txt §6

A. A small favor you absorb

"Done! That one was outside our scope but quick, so no charge this time. For anything else beyond scope I'll send a short quote first."

B. A new feature

"Good idea. It isn't in the current scope, so there are two options: add it now for [price] (delivery moves to [date]), or do it as phase 2 after launch so the current date holds. Which would you prefer? I'll send a change order."

C. An extra revision round

"We've used the [2] included rounds. Further rounds are [price] each. Reply 'go ahead' and I'll start today."

D. The deadline moves earlier

"Here are the options: full scope by [new date] with a [amount] rush fee; core items by [new date] and the rest on the original date at no extra cost; or we keep [date]."

E. A pile-up of small requests

"I've listed the extra requests from the past few weeks: [list]. Together they come to about [X] hours. I suggest one change order for [price]. Once it's approved, I'll fold them into the next delivery."

F. Asked on a call

"Let me check how that fits the scope and come back to you by email today."

THE RULE BEHIND EVERY SCRIPT

Never agree to a price or timeline live. Confirm it in writing.

Handling Price Pushback



Eight things clients say about price, and a reply for each that keeps your rate whole. Cut scope, not the number.

The one rule: when price comes up, change what's included, never just the price. Each reply uses Maya's quote (Essential 1,900 · Standard 2,700 · Premium 3,250). Plain-text copies: scripts-and-templates.txt \$7.

1

CLIENT

"Can you do it cheaper?"

× DON'T SAY

"I guess I could do 2,200 instead."

✓ SAY THIS

"The price reflects the work in each package, so I keep it the same. If budget is tight, Essential gets you the core result (refreshed logo and palette) for 1,900."

Why it works: you offer a cheaper option without suggesting your price was padded.

2

CLIENT

"Another freelancer quoted less."

× DON'T SAY

"Oh, how much? I can match it."

✓ SAY THIS

"That makes sense. Quotes often cover different things. Mine includes two revision rounds and a mini brand guide. If you send me theirs, I'll tell you honestly where they differ."

Why it works: it moves the comparison from price to what's included.

3

CLIENT

"We don't have the budget right now."

× DON'T SAY

"No problem, what can you afford? I'll make it work."

✓ SAY THIS

"Understood. Two options: we start with Essential now for 1,900 and add the social media kit later, or I hold this quote until [date] and we pick it up when the budget is there. Which suits you better?"

Why it works: both options are a yes, and neither lowers your rate.

4

CLIENT

"Can we start now and pay later?"

× DON'T SAY

"Sure, just pay me when you can."

✓ SAY THIS

"I start every project with a 50% deposit; for Standard that's 1,350. If cash flow is the issue, I can split the remaining 1,350 into two payments of 675: one when you approve the first concepts and one on delivery."

Why it works: you stay flexible on timing but never work without a deposit.

5

CLIENT

"Can you do a free sample first?"

× DON'T SAY

"OK, I'll mock up a quick logo idea for you."

✓ SAY THIS

"I don't do free concept work, but here are [2-3] similar projects with the brief and the result: [links]. If you'd like a smaller first step, Essential starts with a 950 deposit."

Why it works: past work is the proof, and a small paid step replaces free work.

6

CLIENT

"We'll have lots more work for you later."

× DON'T SAY

"Great, then I'll do this first one at a discount."

✓ SAY THIS

"Great to hear, I'd like that too. I price each project on its own. Once we've done a few together, I'm happy to talk about a monthly retainer with priority time."

Why it works: future work gets a real agreement later, not a discount now for a promise.

7

CLIENT

"If we book six months of work, can we get a discount?"

× DON'T SAY

"Sure, let's say 25% off everything."

✓ SAY THIS

"For a fixed six-month commitment, paid monthly in advance, I can take 5% off the monthly fee. Booked time saves me sales and admin work, so I pass part of that on. Without the commitment, my standard rates apply."

Why it works: the discount buys you something real: guaranteed, prepaid work.

8

CLIENT

"Can you send an hourly breakdown?"

× DON'T SAY

"Sure: 2 hours discovery, 12 hours logo, 4 hours revisions..."

✓ SAY THIS

"I price by package, not by the hour, so you know the total up front and it doesn't grow if a task takes longer. Here's what each package delivers: [list]. If one item isn't needed, tell me and I'll quote a version without it."

Why it works: you talk about deliverables, not hours to haggle over, and removing scope stays possible.

BEFORE YOU REPLY TO ANY OF THESE

Reply in writing, not live on a call (script F in Chapter 3). Keep the reply short: one sentence on why the price stays, one option that changes the scope, one question that moves things forward.

Raising Your Rates



Know your break-even before you send the email. Then give notice, keep it short, and stick to it.

When to raise

Any one of these is a good reason to review your rate:

- **Your floor went up.** Costs, taxes or billable hours changed. Re-run the Floor Rate tab; your rate must stay above the new floor.
- **You're booked out.** Most weeks you turn work down or push start dates back.
- **Your rate hasn't changed in 12 months.** Your costs have.
- **Clients say yes without any discussion.** If nobody ever pauses at your price, you may be below the market.
- **Your work delivers more.** A new skill, better results, a portfolio piece clients ask about.

How to do it

1. **Run the Rate Increase tab** first, so you know how much work you could lose and still earn the same (next page).
2. **New clients:** quote the new rate from today. No announcement needed.
3. **Existing clients:** give written notice, at least [30] days. Projects already in progress keep the old rate.
4. **Keep it short.** One reason at most. Don't apologize and don't list your costs.

CHAPTER 5 · WORKED EXAMPLE

Maya raises from 90 to 100

Maya bills about 88 hours a month ($1,056 \div 12$). She expects that some clients will leave over a new rate and estimates 5% of her client hours.

Rate Increase tab	Maya	How it's calculated
Current hourly rate	90	input
New hourly rate	100	input
Current monthly billable hours	88	input
Client hours she expects to lose	5%	input (her estimate)
Current monthly revenue	7,920	90×88
New monthly revenue	8,360	$100 \times (88 \times 0.95 = 83.6)$
Change per month	+440	$8,360 - 7,920$

BREAK-EVEN CLIENT LOSS

$$1 - \text{current rate} \div \text{new rate} = 1 - 90 \div 100$$

10% Maya could lose up to 10% of her client hours and still earn 7,920 a month.

At her estimated 5% loss she earns 440 more each month and gets 4.4 billable hours a month back for sales, learning or rest. If she lost more than 10%, she would earn less, so the tab shows the verdict as well.

USE YOUR OWN ESTIMATE

Nobody can tell you how many clients will leave. Go through your client list, mark the ones you think might go, and add up their hours. That share is your input.

What if more clients leave, and it takes months to refill?

Break-even is a single number. Your bank account works month by month. Before you send the email, stress-test the raise: assume you lose **more** than break-even, and that new clients at the new rate fill the gap slowly. [pricing-calculator.html](#), **Step 5** builds this 12-month table from your own numbers.

Maya's stress test: 90 to 100, 88 hours a month, she loses **15%** of client hours (13.2 h, more than her 10% break-even) and refills them evenly over **4 months** (3.3 h a month) with new clients at 100.

Month	Hours billed	Revenue at 100	vs. 7,920 today	Running total
1	74.8	7,480	-440	-440
2	78.1	7,810	-110	-550
3	81.4	8,140	+220	-330
4	84.7	8,470	+550	+220
5	88.0	8,800	+880	+1,100
6 to 12	88.0	8,800	+880 each	+7,260

CASH CUSHION NEEDED

The running total bottoms out in month 2.

550 keep at least this in reserve

WORST CASE: NO REFILL

74.8 h × 100 every month.

-5,280 over 12 months (-440 a month)

The formula: hours in month m = kept hours + refill per month $\times (m - 1)$, capped at today's hours. Kept hours = $88 \times (1 - 15\%) = 74.8$. Refill per month = $13.2 \div 4 = 3.3$.

If the worst case would hurt, raise for new clients first (Email B) and move existing clients later, or phase the raise (reply 4 on page 25).

Email A: existing client, with notice

COPY-PASTE · scripts-and-templates.txt §8A

Subject: My rates from [February 1]

Hi [Name],

I'm writing to let you know about a change to my rates. From [February 1], my hourly rate will be [100] (currently [90]), and my project packages will go up in line with it.

Any project already in progress, and anything you book before [February 1], stays at the current rate.

Thank you for working with me over the past [year]. If you'd like to book work before the change, reply to this email and I'll hold the dates.

Best,

[Your name]

Email B: new clients only

Use this when the new rate applies to new clients first, and current clients keep their rate for a while.

COPY-PASTE · scripts-and-templates.txt §8B

Subject: A quick update on my rates

Hi [Name],

A quick update: from [February 1], my rate for new clients goes up to [100] per hour. As an existing client, you keep your current rate of [90] until [July 31]. After that, the new rate applies to all new projects.

Nothing changes for the work we already have planned. Thank you for being one of my first clients.

Best,

[Your name]

When they reply

Three replies you are likely to get, and what to say. Plain-text copies: scripts-and-templates.txt §9.

1

CLIENT

"That's more than we budgeted for."

✓ SAY THIS

"Understood. Two options: book the next project before [February 1] at the current rate, or we adjust the scope so it fits your budget at the new rate. I'm happy to suggest what to trim."

2

CLIENT

"Can you keep our old rate?"

✓ SAY THIS

"I value working with you, which is why I'm giving you notice and keeping your current rate until [date]. After that, the new rate applies to all my clients, so it stays fair for everyone."

3

CLIENT

"We'll have to find someone cheaper."

✓ SAY THIS

"I understand, and thanks for telling me. If it helps the handover, I'll send the final files and my notes from our projects. If you'd like to work together again later, my door's open."

STICK TO IT

Once the email is sent, don't negotiate the rate itself. Change the scope, the timing or the package, the same way as in Chapter 4.

Email C: retainer or regular client

COPY-PASTE · scripts-and-templates.txt §8C

Subject: Your monthly fee from [April 1]

Hi [Name],

A heads-up on fees: from [April 1], the monthly fee for [4 articles a month] will be [1,750] (currently [1,500]). The work stays the same: [same deliverables, same turnaround, same monthly call].

If you'd rather keep the fee where it is, we can move to [3 articles a month] at [1,500] instead. Just reply with which you prefer by [March 15]. Thanks for [two years] of good work together.

Best,
[Your name]

Three more replies you may get:

4

CLIENT

"Can you phase it in?"

✓ SAY THIS

"Yes. The rate goes to [95] from [February 1] and to [100] from [May 1]. Both dates are fixed, so you can budget for them now."

5

CLIENT

"Will you lock our rate if we sign for a year?"

✓ SAY THIS

"Yes. With a 12-month agreement, paid monthly in advance, I'll hold [100] for the whole term. Without it, I review rates once a year with [30] days' notice."

6

CLIENT

"(No reply after a week.)"

✓ SAY THIS

"Hi [Name], just checking that my note about rates from [February 1] reached you. You don't need to do anything unless you'd like to book work at the current rate before then. Happy to answer any questions."

Plain-text copies: scripts-and-templates.txt §8C and §9. Moving a writing client from per-word pricing to a fixed fee? See Chapter 6.

Retainers & Per-Word Rates



For ongoing work: find out what a per-word or per-piece rate really pays per hour, then turn it into a monthly fee.

Worked example: **Theo** (fictional), a content writer six years in. He writes 1,500-word blog posts for software companies at 0.12 per word. His floor rate, from the Floor Rate tab with his own numbers, is **70**.

Time per post (track your next 3 pieces)	Hours	Formula
Research and interviews	1.5	effective hourly = price per piece ÷ total hours
Outline and draft	3	minimum per piece = total hours × floor rate
Client edits	1	
Briefing, emails, invoicing	0.5	minimum per word = minimum per piece ÷ words
Total per post	6	

THEO TODAY

$1,500 \times 0.12 = 180$ per post

$180 \div 6 \text{ hours}$

30 per hour, well under his floor of 70

THEO AT HIS FLOOR

$6 \times 70 = 420$ per post

$420 \div 1,500 \text{ words} = 0.28$

0.28 per word, or 420 per post

Count every hour a piece takes, including edits and emails. Most of the gap between a per-word rate and a real hourly rate is in those hours. [pricing-calculator.html](#), **Step 4** does this math.

Turn it into a monthly fee

THE RETAINER FORMULA

monthly hours = pieces × hours per piece + fixed monthly hours (planning call, reporting)

monthly fee = monthly hours × rate × (1 - commitment discount), rounded up to 50

Theo offers three retainers: 6 hours per post, 2 fixed hours a month, rate 70, 5% off for a 3-month minimum paid in advance (the same deal as pushback reply 7).

Retainer	Hours	× 70	−5%	Monthly fee	Per post
Starter: 2 posts	14	980	931	950	475
Growth: 4 posts	26	1,820	1,729	1,750	437.50
Full: 6 posts	38	2,660	2,527	2,550	425

Retainer terms to write down

- **Billing:** invoiced on the 1st, paid before the month's work starts.
- **Term:** 3-month minimum, then [30] days' notice from either side.
- **Unused pieces:** roll over one month at most, then expire.
- **Extra pieces:** 420 each (6 h × 70), quoted before work starts.
- **Rate review:** once a year, with [30] days' notice (Email C).

COPY-PASTE · scripts-and-templates.txt §10

Subject: A simpler way to work together each month

Hi [Name],

Since we're doing [about 4 posts] a month, I'd like to offer a fixed monthly package instead of per-word invoices: [4 posts a month], research, one round of edits and a [30]-minute planning call, for [1,750] a month, invoiced on the 1st. It runs for [3] months to start, then month to month with [30] days' notice.

You get a fixed budget and guaranteed slots in my calendar. Shall I send the agreement?

Best,

[Your name]

WORKSHEET 1

Your numbers

Fill in by hand, or use the Floor Rate tab. Maya's values are shown for reference.

Input	Your value	Maya
Take-home income goal (after tax)		60,000
Business costs per year		6,000
Effective tax rate		25%
Savings buffer		10%
Working weeks per year		44
Hours per week		40
Billable share		60%
Hours in a day rate		8
Result	Your value	Maya
Revenue needed per year		94,600
Billable hours per year		1,056
Floor hourly rate (round up to 5)		90
Floor day rate		720
Monthly revenue target		7,883

Rate I will quote: _____ Market rates I found: _____

Review again on (date): _____

WORKSHEET 2

Your quote

Tier 1 = all packages, 2 = Standard + Premium, 3 = Premium only. Add a task's hours to every package column it belongs to.

Client: _____ Project: _____

Task	Hours	Tier 1/2/3	Essential h	Standard h	Premium h
Total hours per package					
× rate × (1 + contingency) =					
Price, rounded up					
Deposit					

Quote rate: _____ Contingency %: _____ Deposit %: _____

Planning tool, not tax, legal or financial advice.